



profile or private window to approximate what a stranger sees. Private browsing does not make you anonymous, but it can reduce local history and separate the audit session from some existing cookies and logins.

Before proceeding, list your known identifiers:

1. Full legal name and common variations.
2. Nicknames, initials and former names.
3. Primary and old email addresses.
4. Current and previous phone numbers.
5. Usernames, gamer tags and pen names.
6. Company, college, school and city combinations.
7. Profile photographs and logos.
8. Websites or projects associated with you.

This becomes your search dictionary. Do not enter highly sensitive identifiers such as Aadhaar, PAN, passport or bank-account numbers into ordinary search engines merely to see whether they appear. Search only enough digits to recognise an exposure when there is a specific reason, and avoid copying sensitive findings into untrusted websites.

Step 1: Search the web as a stranger

Begin with exact-match searches by placing an identifier inside quotation marks. Search your full name, then combine it with a city, employer, college, profession or username. A common name may produce thousands of irrelevant results, so context matters.

Try searches such as:

- "Aarav Mehta" Pune
- "Aarav Mehta" designer
- "aaravm90"
- "oldaddress@example.com"
- "98765" together with your name, using only a partial phone number

Repeat the exercise in more than one search engine. Check the ordinary results, image results, videos, news and documents. Search in English and in Indian-language spellings you have used. Look beyond the first page. Old event PDFs, association directories and competition results often rank poorly but remain publicly downloadable.

Record each relevant result instead of acting immediately. Capture the URL, what it exposes, whether you control the page and how urgently it needs attention. Take a screenshot when the information could change or when it may be needed as evidence.

Google's "Results about you" feature can help locate search results containing personal contact information such as a home address, phone number or email address, and eligible results can be submitted for removal from Google Search. Removal from search results does not necessarily delete the material from the website hosting it, so the source page may require a separate request.

Step 2: Follow your usernames

Usernames are powerful linking devices. A handle created for a gaming forum at age sixteen may later be reused on Instagram, GitHub, Reddit or a professional community. Anyone searching that unusual string can connect conversations that you assumed belonged to different audiences.

Search each username inside quotation marks. Add words such as "profile", "member", "forum", "comment" and "review". Note accounts you recognise, copied profiles you did not create and pages that quote your posts. Then search variations: added numbers, removed underscores, reversed initials and common spelling mistakes.



Do not assume that changing a display name breaks the connection. Many services retain a stable account address, profile URL or user ID. Old mentions by other people may also preserve the previous name. Your audit should record both the visible identity and the underlying account link.

Next, examine biography reuse. A distinctive sentence such as "coffee-fuelled robotics tinkerer from Kochi" can act like a username. Search unusual phrases from old profile descriptions inside quotation marks. Reused wording may connect a pseudonymous account to a real-name profile even when the photographs and handles differ.

Step 3: Audit photographs and visual clues

Your face is not the only identifying feature in an image. A